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"The majority are left behind": the promotion of bilingual education 2030 policy in Taiwan and its potential to widen horizontal inequalities

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Abstract
English as a medium of instruction (EMI) is commonly adopted as a strategy for higher education internationalisation. While there are numerous studies on the teaching practices of EMI programmes, the relationship between EMI and structural inequalities has been less investigated, especially in "universal" higher education systems. To address the research gap, this study investigates the EMI practices of two Taiwanese higher education institutions (HEIs) under current government initiatives. Qualitative data from policy documents and semi-structured interviews are analysed with an institutional logics approach and reflexive thematic analysis. The findings suggest that while state, managerial, and academic logics jointly shape EMI strategies in the public university case, EMI practices in the private university of technology case are predominantly driven by market and managerial logics and challenged by academic logic. Furthermore, this study reveals the structural "stuckness" encountered by the private case. In Taiwan's hierarchical higher education system, the promotion of EMI could result in widening horizontal inequalities among HEIs. More specifically, under the EMI grading certification scheme for students and the tiered award system for HEIs, the majority may be left behind whereas the few with linguistic capital are spotlighted. Therefore, this study concludes that in light of organisational conditions, policymakers should allow greater flexibility for HEIs to develop performance indicators appropriate to their students' needs.

Keywords English as a medium of instruction · Bilingual education · Language policy · Higher education internationalisation · Educational inequality

Introduction

English as a medium of instruction (EMI) has become a global phenomenon in recent decades (Kedzierski, 2016; Pulcini & Campagna, 2015). In Europe, EMI prevalence has been attributed to the Bologna Process and Erasmus programmes (Phyak & Sah, 2022).

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In Asia, EMI has been regarded as a primary means to "internationalise" higher education systems (Kedzierski, 2016). As Galloway and Rose (2015) state, internationalisation movements "are inextricably linked with increasing the role of English in the university setting" (p.230). In this context, Turkey implemented EMI in private universities following the Higher Education Act in the 1980s to escalate its scientific competitiveness (Aslan, 2018). Japan has also encouraged higher education institutions (HEIs) to provide EMI courses through the *Global 30 Project* in 2001 and the *Top Global University Project* in 2014, leading to a significant increase in international students from 117,302 in 2004 to 312,214 in 2019 (Japan Student Services Organization[JASSO], 2019; Rose & McKinley, 2018). In Korea, since the 1995 Education Reform, EMI has been applied as an internationalisation strategy benefiting domestic and international students (Kim, 2021). While higher education internationalisation includes cross-border and on-campus activities (Knight, 2012), these EMI policies are believed to ease international students' obstacles in cross-border learning and facilitate on-campus multicultural teaching.

In this trend, Taiwan is not an exception. In 2018, the Taiwanese government announced the *Blueprint for Developing Taiwan into a Bilingual Nation by 2030*, with an ambition to make English a major language of Taiwan (Ferrer & Lin, 2021; Taiwan's Executive Yuan, 2018). Following this policy, Taiwan's Ministry of Education (MOE) has promoted EMI in HEIs (Taiwan's Ministry of Education, 2021). While there are numerous studies focusing on EMI issues (see Doiz et al. (2012) for European and Asian contexts and Walkinshaw et al. (2017) for Asia-Pacific studies), Taiwan is a context less discussed. In particular, unequal access to English-taught courses is under-researched in "universal" higher education systems such as Taiwan and Japan. In a recent review article on inequality research, Deem et al. (2022) point out that the inequality of educational participation is less explored through qualitative methods, with studies looking into institutional-level practices as a relatively new line of inquiry. Hence, this study expects to offer critical insights into structural inequality issues by investigating EMI strategies at national and institutional levels. More specifically, this study highlights power and structural inequalities in Taiwan's higher education system that may be exacerbated through EMI.

The remaining parts of this paper are composed of five sections. It begins with a review of the relevant literature on the relationship between EMI and social inequality. The theoretical framework used to identify the logics shaping government policies and institutional EMI practices is then introduced. In the "Taiwan's higher education system and current internationalisation policies" section, an overview of Taiwan's higher education system and its current language-of-instruction policy is provided. The "Case study: EMI implementation at two Taiwanese HEIs" section presents case selection criteria and an analysis of two Taiwanese HEIs. Policy implications and research suggestions are discussed in the "Conclusion" section.

EMI implementation and social inequality

Since its proposal, the concentric circle model of Kachru (1985) has long-lastingly impacted the theorisation of English diffusion. The inner circle comprises English-speaking countries that spread English to their colonies in the outer circle. In this situation, outer-circle countries, such as Singapore and India, generally recognise English as their second language. In this model, Taiwan is situated in the expanding circle where English is a foreign language (Kachru, 1990). In the context that English has

become a *lingua franca* under neoliberal trends, an exuberant boost of English education in the expanding circle has been witnessed. With globalisation, "Englishisation" has facilitated the development of a global knowledge economy and borderless talent mobility (De Wit, 2011). Nevertheless, it simultaneously reinforces "English linguistic imperialism", which represents the cultural and structural inequalities between the dominant English and other languages (Aslan, 2018; Phillipson, 2015).

In recent decades, the internationalisation of higher education (IoHE) has been a significant driving force of EMI prevalence (Hu et al., 2014; Rose & McKinley, 2018). A widely accepted definition regards EMI as "the use of the English language to teach academic subjects (other than English itself) in countries or jurisdictions where the first language of the majority of the population is not English" (Macaro et al., 2018, p. 37). In East Asia, "English medium" is almost considered synonymous with "internationalisation" and will not only attract international students but also create international-like experiences for domestic students (Rose et al., 2022; Rose & McKinley, 2018). As Kedzierski (2016) suggests, the prevalence of EMI in this region is established on a neoliberal imaginary that presumes "a chain of equivalence between economic prosperity, modernisation, social mobility and proficiency in English" (p. 385). In this situation, the benefits of EMI are strongly envisaged.

However, English may serve as a gatekeeper for social mobility. Based on the Chinese context, Hu et al. (2014) reveal that with higher tuition fees and admission requirements, EMI programmes strengthen English as a linguistic capital exclusively accessible to those with better socioeconomic resources. In South Korea, Choi (2021) finds that EMI promotion exacerbates socioeconomic polarisation and social stratification among university students with varied English proficiency. Similarly, Sahan (2021) argues that social disparities have been widened as EMI courses are primarily offered in elite Turkish universities. Therefore, instead of fostering social mobility as imagined, EMI programmes may, in contrast, consolidate social structures by increasing linguistic capital and positional goods to certain social groups.

Nevertheless, if EMI only benefits certain social groups at others' cost, how are such policies legitimated? In conformity with Kedzierski (2016), Price (2014) shows that neoliberal discourses, though in fact favour language education providers, serve to legitimise English language education in Taiwan. Especially in this post-Confucian society, the responsibility for education lies primarily with individuals and families (Marginson, 2013). In this situation, neoliberal discourses assuming that English proficiency will lead to promising educational and career prospects may further naturalise the existing social order. Among the few literature reflecting on this controversial belief, most are grounded on either national policy reviews (Ferrer & Lin, 2021; Li et al., 2021) or a single case study (Graham et al., 2021).

Adding to these critical reflections, this study aims to contribute to a deeper understanding of the relationship between current EMI initiatives and the persisting social structure. In this way, I echo the call of Bowles and Murphy (2020) for "more political economic studies of university-based populations with a focus on the presumed socioeconomic benefits of EMI" (p. 21). While national policies are primarily dominated by neoliberal discourses, it is necessary to investigate organisational practices in order to identify the embodiment, coexistence, and interactions of multiple forces. Hence, this study utilises an institutional logics approach to examine the ideological debates on Taiwan's EMI implementation.

Analytical framework: the institutional logics approach

Institutional logics are "the socially constructed, historical patterns of material practices, assumptions, values, beliefs, and rules by which individuals produce and reproduce their material subsistence, organise time and space, and provide meaning to their social reality" (Thornton & Ocasio, 1999, p. 804). This definition reveals that institutional logics are constituted by both material and symbolic elements. More specifically, the material basis refers to social structures and actors' corresponding practices, and the symbolic aspect relates to the ideas and meanings constructed in a particular sociocultural context (Thornton et al., 2012). With such contextual awareness, this approach is flexible for analysing language-of-instruction policies, which are highly context-dependent.

Following Thornton and Ocasio's (2008) typology, four logics potentially influence Taiwan's EMI implementation: *market*, *managerial*, *academic*, and *state* logics. In *market* logic, students are consumers, while universities are the marketers competing to provide educational products. In this context, universities tend to engage in market-oriented decisions in order to dominate significant market positions (Rhoades et al., 2019). Furthermore, *managerial* logic represents intra-organisational changes that universities are "corporate actors oriented towards market competition and that performance should be managed through a well-defined hierarchy, where authority rests on the top management and it is legitimised by hierarchical relationship" (Canhilal et al., 2016, p. 177). The third logic, *academic* logic, highlights HEIs' role in producing and disseminating knowledge. In this logic, professional knowledge and personal expertise are the primary sources of institutional legitimacy (Thornton et al., 2012). A university's status is evaluated by its reputation among peers and the quality of research and teaching. Lastly, *state* logic can be characterised as generating resource distribution and increasing public welfare through democratic participation and bureaucratic domination (Thornton et al., 2012).

With this theoretical framework and based on empirical evidence, this study aims to address the following questions:

1. What are the underlying logics shaping EMI strategies at governmental and institutional levels?
2. How may EMI strategies affect Taiwan's hierarchical higher education system?

Taiwan's higher education system and current internationalisation policies

Taiwan has a dual-track system, including academic and polytechnical education. The former institutions are universities, whereas the latter are universities of technology. To meet the market's demand for skilled labour, Taiwan's higher education system was expanded in the 1980s. This expansion, mainly realised through technical colleges upgrading into universities of technology, transformed the system into a "universal" stage. Currently, Taiwan has 148 HEIs hosting a total of 1.18 million students, with an enrolment rate of over 80% (Taiwan's Ministry of Education, 2022).

Since the 2000s, IoHE has become a focus of government policies (Chan, 2021). Noting the severe shortage of domestic students due to low birth rates, international student recruitment has been prioritised in Taiwan's internationalisation approach (Ma, 2014).

Under this collective objective, the government introduced policies for different HEIs. The *Top University and Excellent Research Centre Project* (*ATUP*, *2006–2015*) was announced to support 12 research universities, mainly public ones, to become "world-class" universities (Tang, 2019). Meanwhile, 31 public and private HEIs were funded by the *Programme for Promoting Teaching Excellence of Universities* to enhance their teaching practices. According to Lo (2009), these policies facilitated not only horizontal diversification but also vertical stratification of Taiwanese HEIs. A hierarchical system was established, with the 12 public research universities on the top, universities funded for teaching excellence at the second tier, and most universities, mainly private ones, at the lower tier.

On this basis, there are currently three major policies for IoHE. First, considering Taiwan's geopolitical challenges, the New Southbound Policy (NSP) was launched by the Tsai Ing-wen government in 2016. Since the Tsai government holds a more pro-independence attitude, tensions have intensified between Taiwan and mainland China (Li & Zhang, 2017). While mainland China is Taiwan's largest trading partner, the Tsai administration has sought alternative opportunities in Asia-Pacific to compensate for the economic losses and enhance Taiwan's geopolitical position. Against this backdrop, a major goal of NSP is to recruit international students from the target countries, namely, Southeast and South Asia, New Zealand, and Australia.

Furthermore, in 2018, the government announced the *Higher Education SPROUT Project* (*HESP*). This new competitive grant funds all public and private HEIs to improve teaching quality and enhance local connectedness. In addition, 23 of them are given extra funding for pursuing international excellence, such as establishing "world-class" research centres and increasing Taiwan's global visibility (Taiwan's Ministry of Education, 2018).

Compared to the previous ATUP, in which 12 research universities received 85% of the government's annual funding, the 23 globally target HEIs in HESP only share 65% of the total funding (Chang, 2021). In this situation, Hou et al. (2020) argue that Taiwan's higher education policies have transformed from elitism to egalitarianism. However, to what extent the established hierarchical structure would be flattened remains questionable, especially under the most recently launched EMI policy. As a language-of-instruction policy, the *Programme on Bilingual Education for Students in College* (*BEST*) has been implemented since 2021. The role of EMI in internationalising Taiwan's higher education sector is explicitly stated in the policy paper,

> by using English as a medium of instruction to assist universities and colleges in pushing forward "EMI" on a certain level of English proficiency, so as to build a bilingual teaching and learning environment for universities and colleges, and in turns improve the English proficiency of students in higher education and the international competitiveness of universities in Taiwan. (Taiwan's Ministry of Education, 2021, p. 2)

More specifically, the government aims to realise these objectives through four strategies: *focused development*, *generalised enhancement*, *bilingual talent recruitment*, and *sharing and collaboration* (Taiwan's Ministry of Education, 2021). The first strategy, *focused development*, selects four flagship universities and 41 flagship colleges in 25 HEIs as the role models. It anticipates that by 2030, at least 50% of sophomores and first-year master's degree students in these HEIs will take half of their credits in English. Given that the percentage of EMI courses in Taiwanese HEIs was less than 5% (Taiwan's Ministry of Education, 2021), this policy goal seems challenging. The second strategy, *generalised enhancement*, funds 37 HEIs to improve students' and staff's English proficiency and enhance the English learning environment. The third strategy

aims to recruit 500 international teachers with English teaching abilities by 2030. The fourth strategy is establishing regional EMI centres to facilitate collaborations among HEIs.

With these strategies, the impacts of *managerial* and *state* logics are manifested. For one thing, managerial logic is embodied as a top-down process is adopted to select suitable HEIs, with a clear set of key performance indicators (KPIs) and an accountability system for those funded. Under this logic, the government aims to ensure the efficiency of financial resources and hence concentrate funding on those HEIs with more desirable conditions for achieving policy goals. For another, as the mass private education sector is included, it indicates the government's role in distributing financial resources and ensuring overall teaching quality under state logic. Since all four flagship universities establish regional EMI centres, they share the government's responsibility to upgrade local EMI practices and facilitate nation-building. In this way, the Taiwanese government is striking a balance between selective elitism and the overall enhancement of the system.

Nevertheless, the BEST causes heated debates. While some scholars act positively and consider the difficulties as temporary and necessary for transforming Taiwan's higher education system (Liu et al., 2022), others are vehemently opposed to EMI promotion and critique it as "the fantasy of bilingual nation" (Liao et al., 2022). For instance, Ferrer and Lin (2021) point out that although the BEST is officially claimed as a bilingual policy, English is central to the policy document as the other language is not explicitly defined. Such an "Englishisation" ambition not only ignores Taiwan's multilingual nature but also narrows the scope of internationalisation with an excessive focus on English proficiency (Galloway et al., 2020). In this situation, without careful design, the Englishisation of teaching practices may be a self-colonising process and oppress local cultures and epistemologies (Phyak & Sah, 2022).

Moreover, while closely examining the policy reasoning, the BEST highlights the role of higher education in serving industrial interests by expecting students to "even follow the labour migrant inside the global market in response to the industrial deployment in Taiwan" (Taiwan's Ministry of Education, 2021, pp. 1–2). In other words, EMI is valued for "strengthening Taiwan's industrial competitiveness, providing people with quality job opportunities, and elevating Taiwan's economic development" (p. 3).

Here, the impact of *market* logic is demonstrated. In the context of reducing overreliance on mainland China and exploring non-Mandarin alternatives under the NSP, EMI promotion can not only cultivate domestic talents for industries but also alleviate the barriers to international students studying in Taiwan. It is therefore not surprising to identify the significant impact of neoliberal ideology and geopolitical concerns on Taiwan's approach to higher education internationalisation.

Furthermore, how funds are distributed under the BEST policy should be noted to understand the interaction of EMI implementation and the existing hierarchical structure. According to Table 1, all four flagship schools are public, top-ranked, and research universities. Besides these four universities, the 25 HEIs funded to establish flagship colleges are eight public universities, 14 private universities, and three public universities of technology. None of them is a private university of technology. Regarding the 37 HEIs funded for generalised enhancement, 14 are public universities, ten are private universities, seven are public universities of technology, and six are private universities of technology.

This table shows a highly imbalanced distribution of government grants among different types of HEIs. Public universities, hosting 26.6% of all tertiary students, are continuously favoured by policies, as 26 out of 32 are funded. On the one hand,

Table 1 Funding status of Taiwanese HEIs under the BEST

Type		Number of students	Percentages	Number of HEIs	Number of HEIs being rewarded		
					Flagship schools	Flagship colleges	Generalised enhancement
University	Public	315,855	26.6%	32	4	8	14
	Private	324,815	27.4%	38	0	14	10
University of Technology	Public	138,212	11.6%	15	0	3	7
	Private	407,673	34.4%	63	0	0	6
Total		1,186,555	100%	148	4	25	37

Source: organised by the author from the database of the Department of Statistics, Taiwan's Ministry of Education (https://depart.moe.edu.tw/ED4500/Default.aspx)

only six of the 63 private technology universities receive funding for promoting EMI courses. Furthermore, none of the six HEIs is a flagship school or college. While flagship schools and colleges are set as role models for other HEIs, the differences in organisational contexts should be noticed. Meanwhile, the funding amount for different HEIs varies greatly, with the four flagship universities receiving 62.5 million NTD per year on average, and the funding for *generalised enhancement* HEIs ranges from one to three million.

Under the current funding structure, the existing "horizontal inequalities", namely, the stratification within the higher education level, may be widened. In Taiwan, the academic track has a higher status than the technical path, with a few top public universities of technology as exceptions (Tsai & Shavit, 2007). Yu and Chen (2022) further clarify that, in general, public universities are highly selective and dominate higher statuses. Through national standardised examinations, these universities consistently and legitimately recruit high-SES students (Smith et al., 2016).

Although Taiwan has a "universal" higher education system, the educational expansion mainly increases the chances of middle- and low-SES students to enter private universities and the technical track. This highlights the different nature of Taiwan's HE system compared to Anglophone countries, where private HEIs are generally elite institutes. Furthermore, what worsens these students' position is that they pay higher tuition fees while attending HEIs with lower selectivity and statuses (Yu & Chen, 2022). According to Taiwan's Ministry of Education (2022), the range of public HEIs' tuition fees is 2784–3998 USD, while it is 3832–7520 USD for private HEIs. In other words, the highest fee for students in public universities is almost equal to the lowest fee for their cohorts in private universities.

Considering the correlated differentiation of HEIs and students' backgrounds, this study claims that the unequal distribution of government funding for EMI may exacerbate the "hidden" horizontal inequalities in this hierarchical system. While HESP is believed to be designed with an egalitarian intention as mentioned earlier (Hou et al., 2020), BEST may show an elaborate return to elitism in which private HEIs are included but funding is largely allocated to public top-ranked HEIs. The actual situation of such horizontal inequalities is further deliberated in the following case study of two cases.

Case study: EMI implementation at two Taiwanese HEIs

In addition to policy analysis, this study adopts a multiple case study design to answer the *how* and *why* questions at the institutional level (Yin, 2018). A maximum variation sampling technique is used to select the cases. This technique emphasises case heterogeneity in order to construct a holistic understanding of the shared or unique patterns (Suri, 2011). As reviewed above, institutional differences between public/private and academic/technical HEIs under current policies can be expected. Therefore, a public university (case A) and a private university of technology (case B) are chosen. Case A is funded as a flagship university, and case B is supported for generalised enhancement. Although Taiwan's HE system has undergone decentralisation, HEIs tend to follow government guidance closely under a post-Confucian tradition (Marginson, 2013). Hence, both cases have established a Centre for Bilingual Education (CBE) to implement EMI strategies effectively.

Case A is a comprehensive top-ranked public university with over 20,000 students, including more than 1000 exchange students and approximately 2000 international degree students. In 2021, over 10% of the courses in case A were taught in English. To encourage academic staff to deliver EMI courses, case A has provided incentives such as increasing hourly fees, giving a one-time award, and training EMI teacher assistants. On the other hand, case B is a private university of technology with more than 8000 students, including approximately 200 exchange students and over 800 international degree students. Following the BEST, case B started providing EMI courses in 2021. To ensure students' acceptance of English-taught courses, case B currently delivers less than ten courses and will increase gradually. Regarding incentives, the CBE of case B increases hourly fees for lecturers and offers scholarships to students taking EMI courses.

To understand their EMI practices, semi-structured interviews were conducted with academic staff and administrative leaders, such as the Director of the Office of International Affairs, in the two cases. Documents on their EMI strategies, including annual plans, press releases, and public information on websites, were collected to further contextualise the analysis. In total, 15 interviews were conducted, with 7 in case A and 8 in case B.

Based on a reflexive thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2021, 2022), three themes are identified for interviews and documentation: *the necessity and appropriateness of EMI*, *realistic considerations*, and *structural stuckness.* The cases are compared with a method of difference in which their varied organisational tributes are regarded as the source of variation (Rohlfing, 2012). As interaction effects are inevitable in real-world research, this paper strives to describe case contexts adequately while presenting the results.

The necessity and appropriateness of EMI

Interviewees from both cases raised questions about the top-down EMI implementation. Nevertheless, their focuses differ nuancedly. While academic staff from case B questioned the necessity of EMI, their cohorts from case A generally agreed with the necessity but challenged the appropriateness of such an initiative. More specifically, similar to the relevant literature (Chang, 2022; Lin, 2020), interviewees from case B expressed concerns about teaching quality and learning outcomes (B-4, B-6, B-7, B-8). Their attribution confirms the existence of structural inequalities. For one thing, many students of case B come from low-SES backgrounds (B-2, B-3, B-5, B-7, B-8) and can hardly afford the relevant cost of EMI courses, such as English textbooks. As an EMI lecturer said,

> English textbooks are expensive. In fact, thanks to the Ministry of Education's grant, the school has done well to subsidise students to buy English textbooks. However, students still have to pay part of the cost, so they are less willing to buy textbooks. In this situation, complete and systematic learning is lacking. (B-7)

For another, most students chose the vocational education track because they struggled in subjects like English and Chinese (B-4, B-6, B-7). In this context, promoting EMI in case B might be challenging. Some lecturers pointed out that EMI courses were delivered at nearly half the pace of Chinese-taught courses (B-6, B-7). As a lecturer stated,

> EMI is about teaching subject content, not English.....but in Taiwan, the English skills of students in the technical education system must first be improved. So, I have a question: Is EMI really what we need? (B-6)

These opinions showed the interviewees' hesitation in promoting EMI at case B in consideration of students' financial conditions and linguistic abilities. In this situation, EMI strategies were less legitimated and raised academic worries.

On the other hand, informants in case A showed high conformity on the necessity of EMI (A-1, A-2, A-3, A-4, A-5). As a top-ranked research university, informants expected their students to become the bridge between Taiwan and the world (A-1, A-4). From an instrumentalist perspective, high English proficiency is necessary to realise this goal. Furthermore, over 60% of the academic staff at case A have doctorates from English-speaking countries. Interviewees also mentioned that their students had high English scores in national standardised examinations (A-1, A-4, A-6). This not only confirms the high selectivity nature of public universities (Smith et al., 2016; Tsai & Shavit, 2007; Yu & Chen, 2022) but also rationalises EMI implementation in case A with such favourable conditions.

Nevertheless, some informants challenged the appropriateness of EMI strategies. For instance, a department head mentioned the issue of interdisciplinary differences:

> Take the Department of History as an example. If we have to explain the connotations of the Mazu faith, it may be preferable for both students and teachers to use the common language of Taiwan, Chinese, to teach it. Using English to discuss Taiwan's development or beliefs would be strange, especially when the target audience is Taiwanese students. (A-4)

Here, from *academic* logic, the localness of knowledge and academic autonomy are highlighted in consideration of teaching effectiveness. While EMI is promoted by administrative leaders holding managerial values, academic staff expect a flexible and bottom-up approach to enable locally tailored implementation. It aligns with scholars' beliefs that grounded policy-making processes can inform better EMI practices (Phyak & Sah, 2022; Rose et al., 2022).

Another issue is ensuring the quality of EMI courses and keeping students motivated (A-5, A-6). As a linguistic professor suggested,

> Even if students know that this is an important compulsory subject, their motivation may be reduced because they do not understand the content in English very well. If this happens every week, one can imagine that students' learning would be worse. (A-6)

In addition, national examinations related to many disciplines, such as lawyers and public servants, are still conducted in Chinese (A-4). In a practical consideration of examination preparation, this may reduce students' willingness to take EMI courses. To sum up,

driven by *academic* logic, faculty members at case A are concerned with better teaching practices that suit their students' needs rather than achieving government-mandated KPIs (A-4, A-5, A-6, A-7).

Realistic considerations

While the previous theme revealed some concerns about EMI practices, this theme discusses why these case universities respond to this challenging policy. For case A, the administrative executives suggested that internationalisation is a primary reason. As the university's mission is to become "a great university in Asia", establishing English-taught programmes and recruiting more global talents are necessary. In this situation, a leader of international affairs reported that

> We know that bilingual education is an almost unachievable goal, but it is worth a try. …… As the government promotes this policy, we can use it to provide students with more English-taught courses and a better bilingual environment. The university may not have had additional resources to do this, or departments may not have felt it was something they should do. However, with the resources brought by this policy, we can now take the opportunity to internationalise ourselves further. (A-2)

For case A, the BEST provides a valuable framework for motivating departmental actions. As a public flagship university, the role of case A in cultivating domestic talents and contributing to nation-building is generally agreed upon by informants. It was evidenced by the belief of several academic staff that EMI should be not only for international student recruitment but, more importantly, for domestic student empowerment (A-4, A-5). In the context that nation-building and talent cultivation are pursued in a top-down manner, the underlying mechanism of EMI implementation in case A can be concluded as "collectively shaped by state, managerial, and academic logics".

On the other hand, as presented above, students in case B have lower English proficiency and may face difficulties in EMI courses. In this context, international student recruitment is an important reason for its EMI practices (B-1, B-2, B-3, B-4, B-5, B-7). Currently, this university attracts mainly overseas Chinese students and Vietnamese students. However, it aims to explore higher education markets in Southeast Asia, such as Indonesia and Thailand. As a former leader of international affairs suggested,

> EMI will contribute to the recruitment of international students. We have been approached by many countries, such as Indonesia and India, about sending their students here. However, these students need English-taught courses as they cannot speak Chinese. With the BEST, we will be able to accept more international students. The composition of international students will be more diverse and will no longer be limited to specific countries. (B-7)

With a similar consideration, another leader valued the BEST for teacher training:

> A key aspect of bilingual education is that we can train teachers with English teaching capacity, which I consider meaningful for internationalisation. This policy will identify teachers capable of teaching in English so that if international students come and need English-taught courses, we can provide them. (B-4)

These arguments support case B's use of EMI courses as a strategy for meeting the needs of overseas markets, confirming the power of *market* logic. Even though EMI may

not fit most domestic students' learning needs, this policy benefits the university in a realistic way. Under such a market consideration, the EMI implementation at case B can be summarised as "collectively driven by market and managerial logics despite being challenged by academic logic".

Structural "stuckness"

In addition to the abovementioned issues, more critically, this study identifies the structural "stuckness" of private universities of technology and their students. In Taiwan, case B is a private university of technology with a great domestic reputation. The president stressed that pursuing international rankings is not their goal (B-1). Instead, this university emphasises collaborations with local and overseas companies and ensures its students graduate with the necessary employability. Such a decision may be a result of market segmentation and, simultaneously, a reflection of structural "stuckness".

Considering market segmentation, it is reasonable for universities of technology to provide practical-oriented education that fits markets' needs. However, students in private universities of technology typically have less proficiency in English than their cohorts in other types of HEIs (Hsu, 2010). As a senior leader suggested,

> Students in technical universities and colleges are relatively weak in English, so we have to select the most suitable students for our EMI courses by data. The Language Centre keeps records of students' English ability information, so we can find the right students to take the courses. (B-3)

Since the government suggests that students taking EMI courses should have CEFR B2 or above levels of English proficiency, case B applies a corresponding selective process. However, while the BEST suggests a tiered degree certification marking students' credits from EMI courses, it may further label and stratify students. In the government-proposed "EMI Level Certification" scheme, students' performance in EMI learning is rewarded by five levels. EMI level 1 to EMI level 5 represent that students have completed more than 12.5%, 25%, 50%, 75%, and 100% of their graduate credits from EMI courses, respectively (Taiwan's Ministry of Education, 2021). In a credential society, certifications are deemed evidence for students' competencies and differentiate their competitive position (Collins, 2019). In this context, such a system could not only define students with better English ability as the winners but, more crucially, worsen the competitive position of those without an EMI certification. In particular, the "EMI Level Certification" scheme can further stratify students in the same types of HEIs in addition to the previously mentioned structural disparities among different HEIs.

While the BEST aims to "select outstanding schools with international competitiveness, transform them into bilingual beacon schools, and cultivate specialized bilingual talents in professional fields to serve as the models for domestic universities and colleges in promoting bilingual education" (Taiwan's Ministry of Education, 2021, *p. 14*), an EMI lecturer at case B commented on this policy objective:

> Very often, universities have put much effort into the framework set by the government, which tells us that there are several good examples and let us keep going! However, we seem to ignore the other 90% or 95% of cases. (B-6)

From a systemic perspective, the BEST policy may be further stratifying HEIs according to their varied funding statuses, from flagship schools and colleges, generalised

establishment HEIs, to those without grants. In the meantime, at the individual level, the "EMI Level Certification" scheme may differentiate students' positional goods, from students who graduate with different levels of EMI certification to those without one. In other words, the way the BEST has been crafted may "force" all HEIs and students with unequal starting points onto the same battlefield, exacerbating "horizontal inequalities". Since private universities of technology hosted 34.4% of domestic students in 2021 (Table 1), the neglected majority may be left and "stuck" behind.

Conclusion

This study reports varied reasons for the government and the two case HEIs to promote EMI. At the government level, the BEST policy is strongly guided by *market* logic and co-shaped by *state* and *managerial* logics. For the public research university, EMI has been viewed as an effective strategy for IoHE with the support of government funding. In this case, EMI is driven by *managerial, state,* and *academic* logics collectively. On the other hand, for the private university of technology, EMI is generated by *managerial* and *market* logics despite being challenged by *academic* logic. In addition to the progressive increase in EMI courses for domestic students, the main reason for its efforts is to meet the needs of overseas markets and international students. In this view, EMI is valued for institutional financial sustainability and market competitiveness in this case.

Furthermore, while the inequality of access to higher education is a common research topic, this study sheds light on horizontal inequalities in "universal" higher education systems that have not been adequately investigated. Based on a case study of two Taiwanese HEIs, this study suggests that as public universities have more resources to provide EMI courses, it may increase their students' positional goods and worsen the competitive status of students from other types of HEIs. This study regards such exacerbation and widening of horizontal inequalities as *structural stuckness*, reflecting the dilemma encountered by HEIs with a lower position in the hierarchical system (Lo, 2009). In particular, as evidenced by the interviews, students in private universities of technology may typically come from lower SES, pay higher tuition fees, and be less proficient in English (Hsu, 2010; Yu & Chen, 2022). This fact should be carefully considered by policymakers.

In line with Phillipson (2015), this study reveals that "language policy plays a crucial role in the societal structures and practices that consolidate dominance and subordination" (p.22). Such consolidation exists in both international competition and national systems. The role of English as a gatekeeper of social selectivity in national systems may be significant. In Taiwan's context, due to limited resources, EMI courses may be implemented hastily and selectively without preparing students and teachers well. While the government subsidises the chosen HEIs for EMI programmes, it, intentionally or unintentionally, creates the monolingual supremacy of English and deepens the disparity between those who possess linguistic capital and those who do not. In this situation, the BEST may demonstrate an elaborate return to elitist intentions from the egalitarian foundation established by the current government.

Based on these arguments, two suggestions are made for policymakers. First, given that Taiwan is a multilingual society, the government should ensure students' competence in both national and international languages. A recent book focusing on EMI and IoHE also claims that policies could "include local languages and cultures in a

more explicit way, in order to acknowledge the diversity which is an intrinsic feature of internationalization and provide students with a more realistic global outlook" (Bowles & Murphy, 2020, pp. 20–21). Although some Taiwanese universities, such as National Taiwan Normal University, subsidise lecturers for delivering courses in national languages, their impact is far less than that of government initiatives. As a society in the expanding circle (Kachru, 1990), an English-friendly environment may be more desirable than promoting a bilingual future. Meanwhile, since the policy document reflects an instrumentalist viewpoint of EMI, academic staff in both cases pointed out an overlook of intercultural competencies. There is a need to give lecturers a sufficient policy timeframe to redesign EMI courses incorporating local and international knowledge.

Second, the two cases in this study reflect considerable differences in organisational conditions resulting from perpetuating role differentiation and structural inequalities. In particular, although government-set KPIs for *generalised enhancement* schools are lower, several practical difficulties of EMI implementation are still reflected by informants from case B. Some informants claim that English for Specific Purposes (ESP) or English for Academic Purposes (EAP) may be more needed than EMI. Hence, considering contextual variations, HEIs should be allowed greater flexibility to develop KPIs appropriate to their students' needs. Meanwhile, while including private HEIs in the funding scheme demonstrates an egalitarian spirit in Taiwan's context, the funding allocation may be redesigned to further reduce structural inequalities.

Since Taiwan is in the preliminary stages of promoting EMI, more empirical research is needed. As this study only investigates EMI in two types of HEIs, further research could explore EMI practices in public universities of technology and private universities. Furthermore, since the application of an institutional logics approach is still insufficient in non-western settings (Lounsbury et al., 2021), this study engages in theoretical development by utilising it empirically. It is vital to demonstrate the specificity of non-Western cultures and governance systems to avoid epistemological self-colonisation. Following the call of Cai and Mountford (2021), future studies are encouraged to apply this framework to higher education research fields, such as English language teaching or internationalisation (e.g., Qi, 2022). Finally, by using an institutional logics approach, this study focuses more on reasoning and explaining the driving forces of EMI practices. Further research may investigate and theorise the policy outcomes of different HEIs based on the underlying logics identified in this study. Studies may also interview policymakers to understand their considerations of award distribution.

In this study, I advance the discussion on EMI implementation and structural inequalities by linking governmental- and institutional-level discourses. Drawing on the findings, I echo Choi's (2021) caution regarding "the complicit role of EMI that might perpetuate and accentuate a class-based English divide and its inherent equalities" (p. 11). When the Taiwanese government is promoting EMI in HEIs with positive intentions, it is imperative to look beyond the achievement of quantifiable KPIs and rethink the substantive impact of the policy on HEIs and students.

Data Availability The data are not publicly available in order to protect interviewees' privacy.

Declarations

Competing interests The author declares no competing interests.

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